

Strings that Bind

The relationship between MS and her daughter, brought alive in a cloud of jasmine

| By Namita Devidayal |



**MS & RADHA:
SAGA OF
STEADFAST
DEVOTION**
by GOWRI
RAMNARAYAN
Wordcraft
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The first chapter in this book is called 'A Cloud of Jasmine' and that is the fragrance that lingers with you as you read until the end. Along with this scent, you hear the drone of the tanpuras, see that dazzling blue silk sari, and get a sense of the extraordinary love between two people that brought forth some of the most memorable music of our times.

Gowri Ramnarayan's wonderful visual book tells the story of the great singer from Madurai. But this is not yet another biography to add to the many that already exist. It is a book whose subplot navigates the special relationship between MS and her daughter, Radha; it is about the "saga of steadfast devotion".

Their story begins in that intimate and vivid moment in 1936 when a two-year-old girl with sparkling eyes and two well-oiled plaits, is introduced to a beautiful woman as she steps down from a horse-drawn cart in a narrow Tiruvallikeni street. As she is "enveloped in a cloud of jasmine", her father T. Sadasivam says, "Radha, from now onwards, this is your mother". The poignancy of deleting her real mother (Sadasivam's first wife who was still around) from her memory is compensated for by the magical musical journey on which MS takes her, transforming her from a boring Brahmin homemaker into a passionate performing artiste who travels the world. For the rest of her life, she shadowed the woman whose mesmerising voice brought Carnatic music alive in every corner of India.

Radha's exposure to music began the moment her new mother entered her life. She would sit for hours listening to MS practice and would sit with her on stage, remaining completely still and absorbed. As happens in most musical families, the music entered her without her even realising it, and

became akin to breathing. It helped that Radha had a natural sense of rhythm, a photographic memory and natural vivacity. One day, when Subbulakshmi was singing a song at a recital, Radha involuntarily joined her and thus spontaneously began her career in music. An old-timer once remarked, "To see MS on the stage without Radha is to see the sky without the crescent moon. No doubt it is vast and starry, but something is missing."

The book describes how Radha became her mother's enduring shadow. When MS played the role of Meerabai in the eponymous film, Radha played the child Meerabai. She recalls how Jawaharlal Nehru, who attended the premiere, hugged her and congratulated her on her charm. Radha had a brief career as a dancer but, as she grew older and social pressures frowned on this mode of performance, she retreated into supporting her mother. But playing second fiddle never rankled. "Retreating into shadow does not mean the end of individuality,"

she said. "Sacrifice implies loss, but being second voice to Subbulakshmi is indeed a gain. It is my great good fortune to be able to sing with Amma." For most of her life, Radha was not just a musical support to MS, but also assisted her in all her personal matters—until the time she was overcome by tubercular meningitis and bedridden.

Roles were reversed and MS took care of her as if she were a child again. This extraordinary love between the two women is the soul of the biography.

The book is replete with stunning vintage photographs of a bygone world—the days of the Madras presidency and the years that followed, including the nationalist fervour to which MS contributed her music. We live in a time when an MJ becomes an icon whose death captures the imagination of the entire nation, but an MS fades out like a beautiful sepia photograph. For that reason, this kind of book is especially valuable. ■

